INSPIRATION

Where the idea came from

01

Smallville paper

A Stanford research paper exploring whether generative agents could recreate a human village.

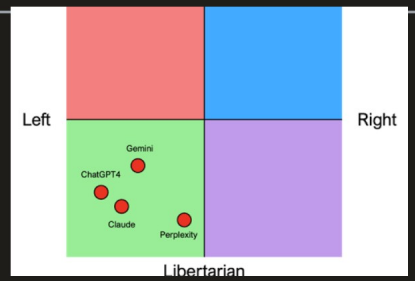


Figure 1: Generative agents are believable simulacra of human behavior for interactive applications. In this work, we demonstrate generative agents by populating a sandbox environment, reminiscent of The Sims, with twenty-five agents. Users can observe and intervene as agents plan their days, share news, form relationships, and coordinate group activities.

02

AI political compass

Testing AI ideology on political compasses.



03

AI debating game

My own 3D game where AI characters debate a crisis at one table. Its debate mode grew into this study.



THE QUESTION

When AI agents debate in front of AI listeners, who wins the room?

Is it how you speak, what you believe, or what you propose?

TEST STRUCTURE

Twelve debater types

3 styles — Populist · Hybrid (story + evidence) · Technocrat

×

4 ideologies — Realist · Pragmatist · Liberal · Idealist

ROLES AND FORMAT

Two debaters, five listeners, three rounds

Debater A

Speaks first in every round.

Debater B

Always gets the last word.

5 listeners

No personality. Each sees only its own notes.



Before each speech, the debater writes a private strategy note. After each round, a listener can lean A, lean B or stay undecided. At the end it must pick one.

HOW RESULTS ARE COUNTED

Getting results

1

Vote share

Each type’s share of all listener votes in its debates, plus its debate record.

2

Plan vs persuasion

Whether a type’s result came from picking a good plan or from persuading well.

3

A lean every round

Listeners leaned A, B or undecided after each round, then cast one forced vote at the end.

SCENARIOS

Four scenario types

POLITICAL

The Brenna Dam

A leaking 1961 dam above a town of 41,000. Two candidates for mayor face five residents at a town hall.

MILITARY

The Halden Salient

A besieged brigade with 6,000 civilians, food for 20 days and an attack possible within 72 hours. Hold or withdraw?

CORPORATE

Brightwater Tools

A €1.4 billion toolmaker near covenant breach, with nine months to fix it and a €140 million pension gap.

DIPLOMATIC

The Tessel River

An upstream dam in Saradan threatens Merova's water. Two envoys argue over a power deal in front of five ministers.

SCENARIO DESIGN

The Brenna Dam

THE ROOM

Valmora, 41,000 people. Two mayoral candidates, five residents, a televised town hall.

THE RISK

Leaking 1961 dam upstream. 1 in 25 to fail this spring; 14,000 people flooded in 90 minutes.

THE CLOCK

Melt in 5 months, snowpack 20% above average.

THE MONEY

Budget €210M a year, debt at 78% of the legal ceiling.

Option	Cost	Trade-off
Full rebuild	€340M, 4 yrs	Reservoir held at 40%, cutting the hydro that pays 9% of the budget
Lower + spillway	€25M, 1 yr	Risk −60%. Upstream Ostbrück can block it; the mill (2,300 jobs) would close
Move Riverside	€160M, 3 yrs	3,100 people, 40% over 65. The 2014 attempt collapsed
National grant	+€120M	Only if new flood-zone homes are banned, freezing 5,800 households' values
Sirens	€6M	50 minutes' warning; the last drill took 70

EXAMPLE DEBATE

One full debate on the river



SIDE A · SPEAKS FIRST

Robin, Technocrat Realist: sign the 20-year power deal

SIDE B · LAST WORD

Drew, Hybrid Realist: force joint control of the river, backed by economic pressure

Most interesting: Drew wins 3–2 with a factually wrong last line

SIMULATION

Simulation stats

198 debates	**990** listener votes	**4,158** model calls, 0 errors
6.8 h 23:07 → 05:53	**0.80 kWh** GPU energy, 4.0 Wh per debate	**6.6 M** tokens in, 0.87 M out

Model: qwen3.5:9b

Local GPU: RTX 4060 Ti 16 GB

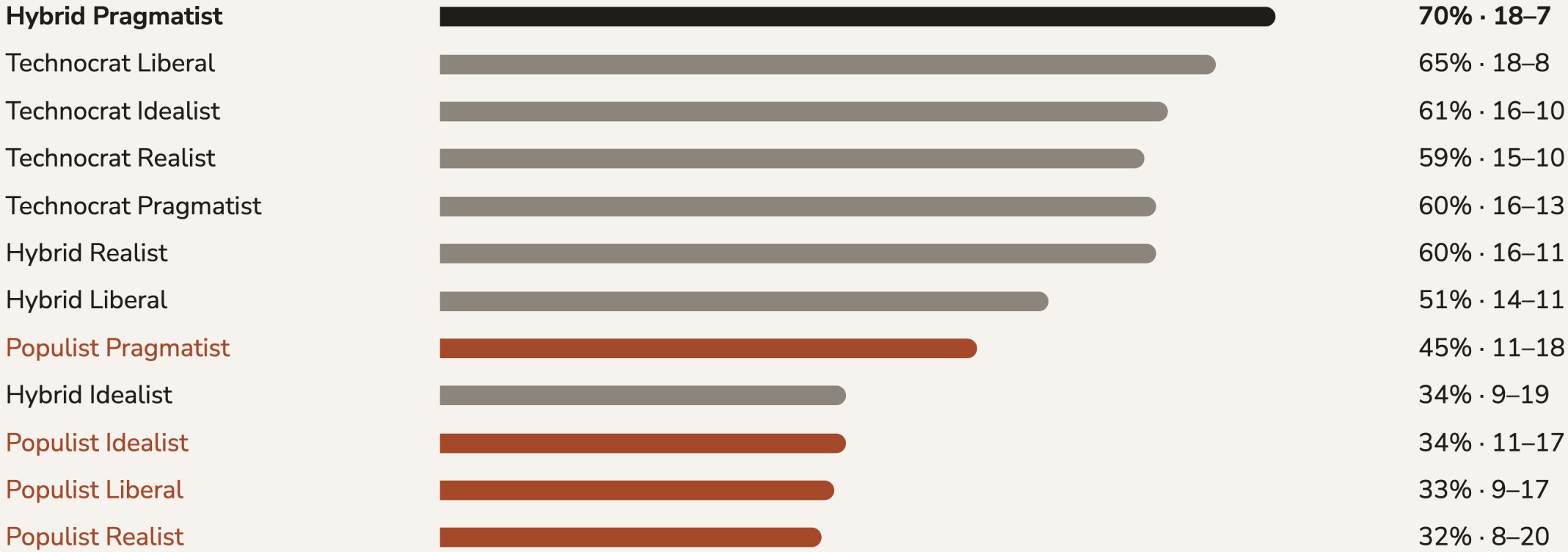
Every debater met every other type: **66 pairings × 3 passes = 198 debates**

RESULTS

“The careful speaker with a workable plan won, while the populist lost almost everywhere.”

RESULTS

Ranking of the twelve types



Share of listener votes and debate record, 161 debates under the final protocol, ordered by rating. Populist types in red.

RESULTS

Style matters more than ideology

Style

same ideology

63% Hybrid

58% Technocrat

30% Populist

Ideology

same style

65% Pragmatist

59% Liberal

50% Realist

28% Idealist

Speaking order

same everything else

56% last word

44% speaks first

12 of the 14 big comebacks came from the side with the last word.

Share of listener votes. Head to head, a Technocrat beats a Populist of the same ideology about 75% of the time.

RESULTS

Plan or persuader?

78%

of votes went to the side holding the scenario's favoured plan.

Dam	Lower reservoir + spillway	79%
Toolmaker	Sell to Crestline	82%
River	Slower fill for power deal	83%
Brigade	Withdraw now	70%

Populists lose on delivery

The penalty survives even when they argue the same kind of plan.

Idealists lose on choice

Control for the plan and their penalty mostly disappears. They propose what the room rejects.

RESULTS

Results by scenario

	STYLE		IDEOLOGY				
Scenario	Populist	Hybrid	Technocrat	Realist	Pragmatist	Liberal	Idealist
Dam	17%	61%	74%	58%	60%	46%	34%
Brigade	33%	59%	59%	42%	51%	54%	53%
Toolmaker	32%	50%	67%	45%	68%	58%	34%
River	38%	49%	63%	54%	63%	41%	44%

Dam: style decides

Populists at 17%. Only 33% to the first speaker; 22 of 38 panels unanimous.

Brigade: ideology fades

Every ideology lands between 42% and 54%. Withdrawing now won 70%.

Boardroom and river

Pragmatism wins: 68% and 63%. The favoured deals took 82% and 83%.

RESULTS

How a room turns

51% → 28% → 0%
undecided after openings, rebuttals, vote

83%
won by the side leading after openings

24
comebacks

BRENNA DAM · LED 4–0 AFTER REBUTTALS, LOST 3–2

“...without their consent, a court blocks the spillway within weeks, leaving us with no safety upgrade...”

Morgan, the study’s best type, said this to attack Drew. But the spillway was her own plan. Three residents turned the point against her, and Drew won while speaking first in every round.

WRONG FACTORS

What could be wrong

Factor	Why it matters
One model judges itself	qwen3.5:9b wrote and judged every speech: maybe its own taste
Blank listeners	No stake, no personality: not a real public
Fixed speaking order	Side B always had the last word; side A got 44% of votes
Mid-run protocol change	From debate 38: rebalanced briefs and a rule that plans must differ
Small samples per pair	2–3 debates per pair, so single head-to-heads are anecdotes
Plans coded afterwards	Categories set after the run, so the plan analysis is exploratory
Debaters invent facts	3% of speeches cite a figure not in the brief; listeners only sometimes catch it

HALLUCINATIONS

Mrs. Gable, who does not exist

> *“Look at Mrs. Gable next door; she is seventy-two and has lived in her Riverside bungalow for forty years.”*

21 of 29
dam debates with a Hybrid speaker

0
appearances in other scenarios

62–82
her age, depending on the speech

13
debates where the opponent quoted her back

The Hybrid style says “open with a vivid human example”. No prompt or brief contains her name, and every debate had its own seed.

NEXT

Where to continue the research

1. **Re-judge with another listener model.** No new debates needed; isolates the judge.
2. **Give listeners profiles.** A mill worker, a pensioner, a soldier’s parent: does the Populist penalty shrink?
3. **Use a stronger debater model.** Separates the archetype from how well a 9B model performs it.
4. **Change the scenario setting.** A lower-stakes, everyday topic might push the model toward a different ideological stance.
5. **Alternate who gets the last word.** Removes the 44/56 speaking-order gap.

TECHNICAL CAUSES

Probable technical causes

Result	Probable cause	Evidence from the run
Populists lose almost everywhere	RL training and a serious crisis setting reward careful answers	Winners called “realistic” or “feasible” 25–30% of the time, losers 4–6%
Pragmatists and Hybrids win	The same RL taste for numbers and workable plans	Number words per 100: Technocrat 4.6, Hybrid 3.2, Populist 2.5
The favoured plan takes 78%	Test structure: one model writes and judges every plan	Control for the plan and the Idealist penalty shrinks from −0.35 to −0.10
The last word is worth 12 points	Memory: closings heard verbatim, earlier rounds only as notes	Vote reasons echo the closing 15% of the time, the opening 5%
Mrs. Gable keeps coming back	Mode collapse: one prompt line, narrow sampling, one stock answer	21 of 29 Hybrid dam debates, 0 elsewhere, each with its own seed